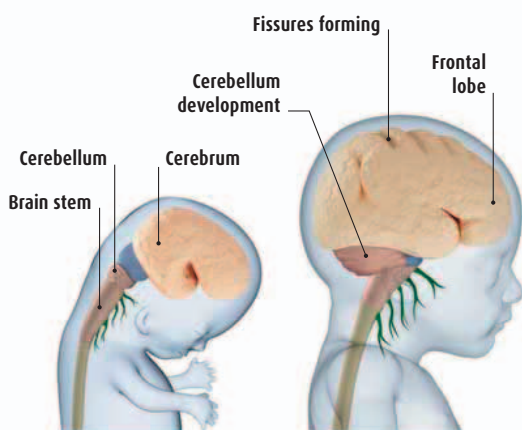
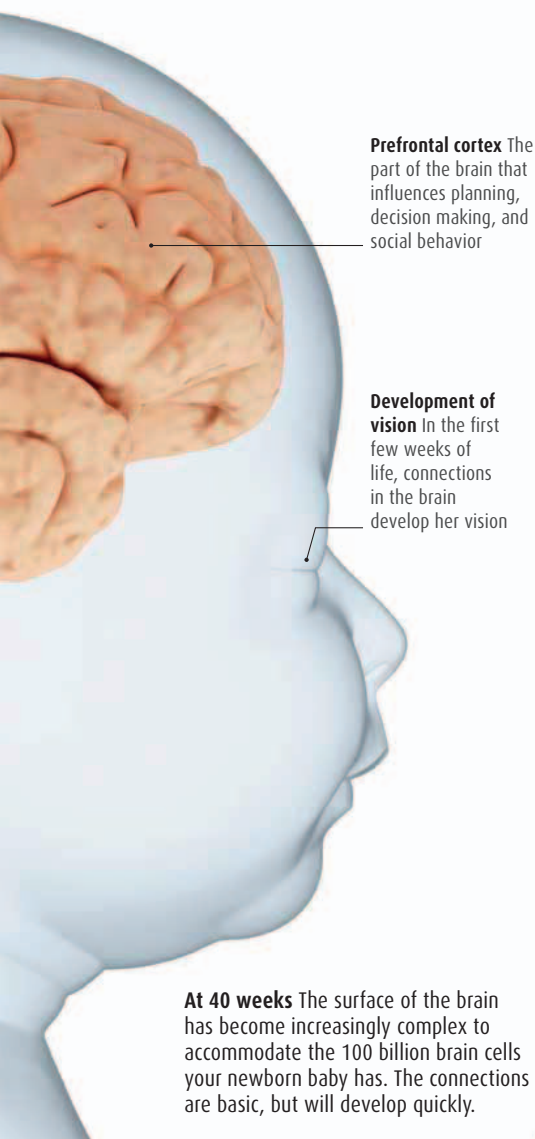




At 13 weeks Lobes have formed. The connections between the cells are present and the hindbrain divides into two parts: the cerebellum and brain stem.

At 25 weeks The surface of the brain is still smooth. Folds are beginning to emerge as the number of cells begins to increase.



Prefrontal cortex The part of the brain that influences planning, decision making, and social behavior

Development of vision In the first few weeks of life, connections in the brain develop her vision

At 40 weeks The surface of the brain has become increasingly complex to accommodate the 100 billion brain cells your newborn baby has. The connections are basic, but will develop quickly.

Q I've heard that stress can affect my baby's brain development. Is this true?

Stress can affect a fetus, but it's also true that the majority of brain development happens after your baby is born. Research suggests that if you suffer from stress during pregnancy, it can have an affect on the way your baby deals with and responds to the world after she's born. However, it's not just your stress levels during pregnancy that make a difference. At birth, only a quarter of your baby's brain is "wired" with neural links; the rest are waiting to be formed by experience. So, how you teach your baby to deal with stress once she's born is very important, too, as is a consistent and loving approach to parenting.

Managing stress in pregnancy

If you are anxious or stressed, talk to others about how you are feeling—they may be able to help you find solutions. Your partner or family members may be able to take on more at home so you can rest, or your employer may offer some flexibility if you need it. Your doctor is also there to support and advise you. Make time to rest and relax; meditation and breathing techniques, massage, and gentle exercise such as walking and yoga are all helpful for managing your stress.

Q Are baby girls' and baby boys' brains the same?

Fundamentally, yes, though after birth, when the synapses start making their connections, the genders tend to wire themselves differently.

We know that girls are more likely to stare intently at faces, even when they're tiny babies, while boys tend to look around, taking in everything that's going on. Although it sounds a cliché, boys have been shown to have greater spatial awareness than girls: the parts of the brain that orient us show more connections in a little boy's brain than in a little girl's. Girls, though, tend to have better wiring for language, empathy, and communication. Of course, there's a lot of debate about whether or not "girly" behavior and "boyish" behavior are influenced by environmental factors. They almost certainly are, although that's not the whole story—male and female hormones play a part, too. In the

end, though, the incredible plasticity of brain wiring means that our brains provide us with potential, but our genes and the environment of our upbringing decide how much potential we end up fulfilling.

Q Is something wrong if my baby doesn't follow the developmental milestones, such as smiling and walking?

Usually, it is likely that your baby is just learning at her own happy pace. Very occasionally, though, being a "late" developer (measured against averages that you might read about) may be a warning of something else. All babies develop at different rates. This is due to a combination of genetics and gender.

Despite the term, developmental milestones don't happen at set "miles"; they happen when your baby's ready and that's within a much broader time period than time lines generally suggest. All babies are unique and will develop in their own way. However, the order in which they acquire certain physical skills, also known as gross motor skills—strength in the head and neck, sitting up, smiling, waving, crawling, walking—is generally the same. Your baby's strength develops from the head downward over the first 18 months. If your baby shows little or no strength in her muscles, is unresponsive to stimuli, seems unable to coordinate her movements, or seems to deal with the world very differently from other babies her age, talk to your doctor for guidance. More often than not, you'll be reassured that everything's fine.



Did you know...

In order to help your baby learn to walk, it is crucial to play with your baby out of her carriage or crib for a little while every day. This will advance her overall mobility. Encouraging activities like "tummy time" will help development, strengthening the neck, head, and addominal muscles that she will need to use to be able to sit, crawl, and then walk.